Meeting Title: Chatbot Development and Market Validation Meeting

Meeting created at: 7th Apr, 2026 - 3:00 PM

Eric Zelman - **00:01**

What am I doing? I filed a patent, provisional patent on the summit.

Don Whalen - **00:24**

That's cool.

Eric Zelman - **00:26**

So that, you know, may or may not hold water. We'll see what happens over the rest of this. You know, how things go forward. I am. What did I do? I filed for an LLC in Rhode Island a couple of days ago so that I could apply for. Basically for grants to help. To, you know, small business grants to help push this thing forward. Because I figured that would be good. So I'm still looking. I'm still totally looking for a role, but I want to get this thing off the ground as much as I can. And I probably now have, I don't know, you know, a dozen, maybe 50, maybe up to 15 people, including yourself, maybe, hopefully, who are going to test this first stage of it. So what else is going on?

Don Whalen - **01:19**

Probably get everybody at Big Tin can to test it, because I think everyone is looking. So. And I'm not even kidding.

Eric Zelman - **01:26**

No, I. I know. I mean, I. I showed it to. I've shown it to a bunch of people. I know that, you know, it's. It's. It's, you know, it's like that.

Don Whalen - **01:37**

Yes. You don't have to say anymore, but that's kind of. And I. Everybody I talk to, I'm like, I'm not. I'm sure you're one of the people who's looking. And I say, I think everybody is.

Eric Zelman - **01:47**

So, I mean, I know that, you know, you said last time. I was really happy to hear that you killed your numbers. So, I mean, like, gave you know, a little breath, but for, like, you know, maybe for that long or for this long, you don't know, you know. So, like, that's it.

Don Whalen - **02:01**

The bunch of people got let go. Was it last week? Ishmael's gone. I don't know if you. You probably heard more than me. I seem to be the last one to know everything going on here. Say again?

Eric Zelman - **02:16**

I heard Andrew left and.

Don Whalen - **02:18**

Yeah, Andrew. John Sullivan, one of the sales guys, one of the original Brainchart guys, Alex Maciag. And then Micah Bruzzi was officially gone at the end of March. That was no surprise. But who else? There's one or two other people I heard, and I'm sure there's others that I just don't know or know about.

Eric Zelman - **02:35**

So. I mean, yeah. So I started Keen a couple nights ago.

Don Whalen - **02:41**

Oh, good.

Eric Zelman - **02:42**

Got some good feedback from him. David's. David's, you know, just brutally honest. He's like, look, I don't know if there's a product here. He's like, this is probably consultancy for you with companies of how they would use this or

if they would use this. I think David feels right now that any software that relies on a website could be basically duplicated using AI. So whether that be. I mean, he's, you know, whether that be big can chop hat or what I'm doing, I think he feels like there's no safe place to because of where large language models are going and how easy it is to build stuff. And I think that with regard to my particular project, I think that his feedback was pretty important. I mean, it's pretty useful.

Eric Zelman - **03:36**

But that maybe this is the kind of thing that someone uses in house, but that, you know, we'll see.

Don Whalen - **03:45**

Well, yeah, I mean, that's. I'm interested to see what you have here. And he's right. But I mean, I don't know how quick all this stuff is going to happen. David's always been kind of ahead of what's coming. So, you know.

Eric Zelman - **03:56**

Yeah, no, so there's a fair amount of the fire and brimstone and I don't know, you know, you. Who knows?

Don Whalen - **04:04**

Exactly.

Eric Zelman - **04:05**

So. So let me try to make great quick work of this so that you can go back to your day. Okay, so where did I leave this with you? So the last time, I think I gave you the whole overview of this. So I'm not going to walk you through slides. I basically just wanted to show you the form and give you a couple tips about trying it out. So what I'm going to ask you to do, I'm going to send you. I think. I don't know if I did send you instructions, I will send you instructions to test out the chatbot front end of this process. What this is going to be is that you are going to spend, hopefully somewhere around 30 to 45 minutes, if you can, working through with the chatbot on your resume and your career arc. Right.

Eric Zelman - **04:56**

So it's not going to build a resume or anything like that, but you're going to upload your resume, maybe upload screenshots of LinkedIn, because I don't have a good LinkedIn scraper. Right. If you have recommendations or things, but basically have you.

Don Whalen - **05:10**

So I'll pause there. Have you tried Apify for scraping LinkedIn?

Eric Zelman - **05:16**

I haven't I've tried Brave.

Don Whalen - **05:20**

Oh, okay.

Eric Zelman - **05:22**

Sorry. No. Browser lists. Wrong. Wrong tool. Browser lists.

Don Whalen - **05:26**

Oh, all right. Okay.

Eric Zelman - **05:27**

And I haven't tried Appify, have you?

Don Whalen - **05:28**

I mean, it's been, I've been messing with a lot of that stuff and just even Zoom info, but LinkedIn doesn't have an MCP that I can find.

Eric Zelman - **05:37**

There's some, there's no MCP.

Don Whalen - **05:39**

Yeah, go to Appify, though. Apify. I think it's dot com. Right. Let me just look here, but check that out. That's something that could scrape. You can scrape, but LinkedIn.

Eric Zelman - **05:50**

So I, I, yeah, no, I will 100 look into that because I'd love to have that. What I'd love to have is the ability for someone to put their profile URL in here and have it just get in, you know, and right now where I'm at is that I'm kind of. We couldn't think of Claude and I, you know, Claude couldn't think of a good way of scraping LinkedIn. So, so yes, I asked people to take screenshots if they want to add it, but the idea here basically is just to flesh this out with as much about you and your career as possible. So it could be like 360 assessments, disc assessments, anything that you think is an honest way. A loser.

Don Whalen - **06:30**

No, I'm here.

Eric Zelman - **06:30**

What the.

Don Whalen - **06:31**

Okay, I think it's my. Hold on. Is it. Come the fake. This, this computer is so old, it's not even a, an Apple silicon. It's still intel. So it, the fan runs, it overheats. Sorry.

Eric Zelman - **06:45**

No, it's okay. No, I appreciate it. I mean, I get it. And so you're going to upload as you know, a few documents. Right? Whatever fleshes it out for you. For some people, it might only be a resume, but I put in like a couple of coaching worksheets that I did a disc assessment or my resume, and then it's going to go through basically a Q A. Now, I've tried it. I've tried to create some guardrails so that it doesn't, you know, AI has this propensity to, just doesn't know when to stop. Right?

Don Whalen - **07:17**

Yes.

Eric Zelman - **07:18**

It doesn't know that you're a person. So it's just, you know, it starts, it goes into full psychotherapy mode after about half an hour. It's like, don, tell us about your childhood. So, so I'm trying to keep it away from all that stuff, but I don't think the guardrails are Perfect. And what I mean by that is that for some people, it might take them 30 minutes. I think Ravi said he spent two hours on this, which is not what I want. And I was really nice of him to spend that two hours, but that must have been painful or. It was great. I haven't heard feedback from him other than I spent two hours. So what I was going to say to you is that when you're in the sections of the chatbot, after about. I don't know, what is it? There's. There's.

Eric Zelman - **08:02**

There's eight sections, right? Six, seven sections. If you're spending more than like five to eight minutes on a section, just tell it, say, let's move on. Because it will always. It will respond to user prompting. I mean, if you try to move on from, like the very beginning, it'll say, no, I really need this. But after a couple minutes or whatever, it gets. It kind of gets enough out of that section to be like, okay, yeah, let's move on to the next section. So if you feel like it's starting to just get wonky, do that. Because I don't want you to spend two hours on this thing, or I don't want you to feel like I'm asking you to spend two hours on this thing.

Don Whalen - **08:41**

So looking at the top, the tabs are materials, right? That's. That's where we're at now.

Eric Zelman - **08:46**

Yep, yep, yep.

Don Whalen - **08:49**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **08:49**

Yeah, yeah. So let's just go back. Let's just go back to the beginning. Just so. Because I didn't. So you upload your materials. Yeah. Guided conversation, and then it outputs a PDF or it gives you the opportunity to download a PDF. There's a button for it. I put a little data privacy thing here at the bottom because Jared Hibbs tried it the other day and was like, you got to put that in there. And I'm like, okay, I'll do that. So I'm getting. I'm trying to get the feedback in real time. And it was great to talk to Jared, too. He's. He's, he's. He's.

Don Whalen - **09:20**

I heard he was not. He out of a job or something, or he left or was let go. I don't know what happened.

Eric Zelman - **09:25**

Yeah, so. So I think that he. He left and then he and Rusty went to some shop and then that collapsed. And then he spent the last few months, maybe six months looking around for a job, but he's starting a new role like next week or something like that.

Don Whalen - **09:41**

Oh, good, good.

Eric Zelman - **09:42**

And in the meanwhile, now I Noticed or I saw the other day on his LinkedIn that he had posted that he had started his own software project, like a. A side gig kind of like this. And it was a. A LinkedIn post creator and. And manager for sales teams.

Don Whalen - **10:02**

I saw that it was po. What did it call it? Post. Whatever the name is.

Eric Zelman - **10:06**

I saw little posts. Something.

Don Whalen - **10:08**

Yeah, little posted or something like that.

Eric Zelman - **10:10**

Yeah. And. And so I asked. So I wanted to chat with him about, like, how did you do it? You know, like, what's it built on? You know, because I'm kind of in that same kind of space. You vibe coded it. Like, what are you doing? How does it. Is it. You know, how do you promote it? Right. All those kinds of questions. We were just chatting for that. And then he was kind enough to also want to test this because he thought I should give him a quick, you know, overview. And he thought this is pretty cool. So he's going to test it and his fiance is going to test it and. Good. So, I mean, there's a lot of goodwill, but it still may not be a useful product. So you're going to upload your content here. Right.

Eric Zelman - **10:47**

And it could be pictures, it could be. You know, I don't think the chatbot really cares much about what it is. I don't know that it knows how to parse, like, YouTube stuff, but I'd like to figure that out in the future because I think it'd be great if someone actually had, you know, audio or video that they wanted to post because, you know, again, what. What is your professional identity or what is your personal identity and how to flesh this out. Could. Could draw across a lot of different kinds of things beyond a resume. And that's the whole point of this. Yeah.

Don Whalen - **11:18**

This is cool. So.

Eric Zelman - **11:20**

So then you're going to put your name in. The chatbot is pretty good at figuring this out. But the other day I was testing it and a couple times it. It got confused and I figured I will just make this easier for it to know the name of the person.

Don Whalen - **11:36**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **11:37**

Pronouns.

Don Whalen - **11:38**

Current situation. Yeah, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **11:40**

Pronouns will get removed if I. If I sell this to the Department of Defense. But, but, yeah, your current situation, because I think also there's a little bit of inflection. I'm not sure the quantity of difference between it when you do the chatbot of, like, are you employed? So you're happy? Are you okay with your role? Are you actively searching? Like, how desperate are you? Are you just kind of in between trying to figure things out and, you know, so There could be different ways of approaching it. So for now you probably just, you know, hit employed. And then there's eight sections really. Seven of these are where you are filling things out and the eighth is where it delivers.

Eric Zelman - **12:25**

So I don't know, eight times seven times eight, you know, about, I don't know, eight minutes, seven or eight minutes a section is probably where it should be. And I'm going to work on the guardrails to prevent future users from getting sucked into a two hour AI vortex.

Don Whalen - **12:45**

I bet Robbie though was probably looking for, oh, here's some writing samples. You gotta, I mean I'm sitting there going, at least I know what I need to go into it. Yeah, I don't think I have any writing samples that, you know, but I guess I would look for that before I started, I think, I mean, you.

Eric Zelman - **13:00**

Know, it could be, yeah, it could be stuff that. And I think it has to. I mean, because it's not like you're not taking writing samples the way that you would when were making avatars, that big tin can. It's, you're really looking for something that speaks about who you are versus how you write. Okay. You know, that's why I think those assessments are really valuable. That's why I think recommendations would, could be really valuable like LinkedIn. You know, people are like, Don did this. Don was great at this. I think. Yeah, I think all that is important and it can give some color to the process. Okay. And then it's going to jump into the chat bot. Right. And it's going to, you know, if I had uploaded something, it would give context here and say, hey, you're a big. And can.

Eric Zelman - **13:47**

And then before this, you know, so it kind of will initially clue in that it scanned that content before it starts chatting to you.

Don Whalen - **13:54**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **13:54**

So you know that I'm not going to walk us through 20 minutes of answering these questions. Right? So at the end, what's going to happen is that you'll get to the end and mind you know, between sections there could be a slight pause of a few seconds while it gathers its thoughts and moves to the next part. So there's that you can also, I include, incorporated a way of doing state management now. So if you walk away from this, you can, it'll. You come back and finish it later versus it forgetting what you did. Right. So that's important too. It'll come back to the beginning of the section that you. So if you're in the middle of a section and you quit it and you come back, it'll come back to the beginning of that section.

Eric Zelman - **14:43**

So at the end what it's going to do is it's going to take, this is canned and it's built into the system, but it's going to take your, your resume, your feedback and it's going to create this document that's meant to be kind of more like pro bullet points. Right. Cool.

Don Whalen - **14:58**

Holy.

Eric Zelman - **14:59**

You know, and so it's going to talk about your career narrative, but it's also going to talk about your mission and direction, like where you want to work, what you want for the future, what you're looking for, how you like to work. Right. What kinds of, you know, like, do you like quick feedback loops? Do you like autonomy? Do you like, you know, a lot of conversation and are you someone who needs to work close to people or you're not? I mean this will all, I think a lot of this hopefully comes out through this kind of dialogue and then you know, things that would be non negotiables and where all of this, what all of this is sort of getting at, right.

Eric Zelman - **15:43**

In this idea of a structured document that would probably print out to be two or three pages as PDF is that as I showed you with that long Rube Goldberg machine of. Here's where I analyze all these different VC firms and try to make fits and things this document is the foundation of. Then what would become at some point if I productize this, a way of taking this and building scores and weights to say, okay, this is how Don likes to work or this is the areas that Don is interested in, or there's the areas that Don is not interested in or where he has a bit of experience, but not a lot. Right.

Eric Zelman - **16:20**

And all of that would then become the math part of it, of figuring out how this goes to become something that is used with weights and measures to look at job descriptions or VC firms if you're me or a host of other things.

Don Whalen - **16:38**

This is cool. Holy shit. This is a lot of work.

Eric Zelman - **16:41**

The other side of this I think I mentioned is that I started building out and so the patent part that I'm excited about, but it may never come to be anything is this idea that this is the candidate side and there is the company side recruitment side. So basically I filed a patent that is the bidirectional signal matching between candidate and company and no one has really gone into this. And I'm trying to figure out why. Right. There aren't a lot of competitive Patents on this, there really isn't anything and there are companies that do some amount of this chatbot discovery stuff but it's very, very superficial and I'm not 100% sure why. I don't know if it's because this tool

isn't needed in the marketplace and that's what I'm trying to figure out.

Eric Zelman - **17:36**

I'm going to talk to Jen Mankiewicz on Wednesday, which I'm excited to do is get some feedback from her because I haven't really talked to HR people, people and culture folks today. My I got this amazing reference or this connection my father in law, I was. This is a Florida story but you know, he knows a lot of well to do people in Florida and so one of their one my stepmother and, or my mother in law really and my father in law, one of their close friends is this woman who ran executive recruiting at Goldman Sachs for 30 years.

Don Whalen - **18:14**

Holy. That's a good resource to have.

Eric Zelman - **18:17**

Yeah, no kidding. I was like okay, game over. And so we spent I don't know, 30 something minutes on the phone this morning I sent her an overview, a document which I'll send you a similar document explaining thesis of what this is about and getting her feedback and how she went about things of recruiting at Goldman Sachs. And she retired 13 years ago. So she missed a lot of stuff. She missed all the. She first off worked at one of the wealthiest companies in the history of civilization. So by the time that she was looking at hiring someone, I mean these are people that she was, I mean again this is 13 years ago, but even back then these are salaries of people who are getting paid 300,000 to 2 million in salary, let alone bonuses. Right?

Eric Zelman - **19:05**

Yeah, it's completely out of my league but, or maybe our league, but, but so she had all the humans to read these resumes and to understand their JDs and to talk to these people because you know, for as many of these people use a Goldman, I mean, you know, like this is like the ultimate boutique for, for that stuff they weren't dealing with like how do I parse through a thousand resumes of people who are going to get paid 50,000 or 60 or 100,000 a year or whatever that is and what she dealt with. Right. But it was really fascinating talking to her about where she thought this would fit. And, and so I got a lot of great feedback from her because she definitely agreed or confirmed some of theories that I have. So that was validating.

Eric Zelman - **19:56**

And, and she Thinks actually this would fit in for recruitment.

Don Whalen - **20:01**

I was just going to say recruiters. Have you talked to any? Like, I have a friend who's a recruiter, so.

Eric Zelman - **20:07**

So I haven't gone to Mike Tui yet, but I. And. But she. And I. I probably should. And. But I think, you know, sometimes recruiters like Mike, I mean, I'll go talk to him and stuff. I'm just talking out loud. Don, I think that, you know, saying to her earlier, there's. There's certain Personas. Like I said earlier, I think I made this joke to you when we had lunch. Like, this tool of, like, look at my career. Look at my through line. Pat Welch would never use this. He doesn't need it. It isn't. It isn't for him. Right? It isn't for him. So there's. There's people who don't clearly need this, and they would never use this in hiring. They just. They just. They're kind of like, I know what I need to know. Right? I look at their resume.

Eric Zelman - **20:53**

I know by talking to them for 10 minutes if they're for real. You know, I saw what they did for closing their. You know, just that kind of signaling. But that said, there are probably a lot of people who don't know this, and I think on the recruiting side, this could be useful.

Don Whalen - **21:08**

Well, I mean, isn't the recruiter supposed to match a job and a person? Like, you're doing that here in a different way, kind of. I mean, but I think you're more thorough because the. The AI is helping with it. I don't know. And.

Eric Zelman - **21:22**

Yeah, yeah, no, I. I think that there's a. I think that's true, or I hope that's true, you know, and. Yeah, so what I'd love is for you to go through this, and then at the end of this. Where's the feedback form? Come on, Zelman. There's a feed. There's a. There's a. I made a feedback form. And. And it's in the email. And you can go through this and just give me feedback on what you think of it.

Don Whalen - **21:54**

Oh, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **21:54**

This is awesome. Detail helps. I just wired up a new version which I haven't deployed yet, which is pretty cool. I'm excited about where it actually has telemetry built into the app, so I can tell where the. You know, when the user logged in, where they gave up, how long they sent and spent in each section. So I can kind of refine the guardrails about how much time it's taken.

Don Whalen - **22:20**

This is unbelievable. What are you hosting? Like this feedback form and the. What's, what's everything hosted on?

Eric Zelman - **22:27**

Yeah. So this is hosted on a tool called Vercel. V E R C E L. Okay,.

Don Whalen - **22:34**

I've heard of that. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **22:35**

Yeah. And so you know what happens is I vibe code this with Claude code, it gets pushed to Git and then push to Vercel and that's where it's hosted. Right.

Don Whalen - **22:50**

Versions on Git, like all the past versions and all that stuff. Okay.

Eric Zelman - **22:54**

Or yeah, I mean, somewhat. I mean I'm kind of clean, I'm kind of iterating through it, so I'm not really keeping the past versions because I know it's too much stuff. Right. But for now. But, but I do keep a lot of things in git certainly, you know. Yes. And then there is. What else? So then the data, as I, I think I mentioned, I'm feeding all the data and all the results into air table. So that's the table I showed you last time we got together. Here's the project. So the feedback forms are going to end up going in here. Right.

Eric Zelman - **23:30**

And you know, and then now with a new build, which you won't have because I don't want to disrupt people, but at some point in maybe about a week, I'm going to deploy it and then it'll be able to tell me where they dropped off session section timings and that kind of stuff and. Yeah.

Don Whalen - **23:48**

And is this aid airtable or is it a free one?

Eric Zelman - **23:53**

I'm paying, I mean I did free for a little bit, but I think I'm paying like 20 bucks a month.

Don Whalen - **23:58**

Yeah, that's what I mean because I, I, I used the free air table a while ago, but then it's like you can't have a, there's all sorts of restrictions so it's cool to try it out. I was just curious. This is so capable, man.

Eric Zelman - **24:10**

So, yeah, so that, that's where this thing stands. And at some point, you know, maybe I'll have the other part to it. The part that I would give to, you know, someone like Jen to say build all, you know, take all your company's mission value missions and the JD and information about the department chair or head. Right. I'm using academic charts. But, and, and because if you're thinking about like I want to hire a new engineering leader or I want to hire, you know, I want to figure out who replaces Eric or whoever, you know, this could be used as an internal tool and this could also be used as an External as a way of looking at. Okay, I have 50 resumes or 100 resumes. Because like I said my.

Eric Zelman - **24:59**

One of my theories, one of my thesis is that, you know, if everyone's doing keyword bingo, that those systems like Ashby and Rippling, at some point you end up with a thousand resumes that all scored really high. And how do you go from a thousand resumes into a digestible size that you can actually figure out? Okay, who do I really want to talk to? And who's going to be an interesting person to follow up with?

Don Whalen - **25:32**

Well, that brings me to a question. So you've probably gone on LinkedIn. I haven't looked on LinkedIn for jobs, but I remember a couple years ago I was looking and there was. You'd see 900 people apply to a job or a 14. It's insane. Is that still the case?

Eric Zelman - **25:48**

Yeah, I'm sure it is. I mean I, I hear that all the time that this, you know, they had 2,000 applicants, you know, for things crazy. And, and as the AI purge gets worse with each version of AI that replaces more of me or the collective us, right. That number is going to go up. Because I don't think that the. Sir, I think what I think has happened, I mean, you know, who's to say? But I think in certain industries, the surface area of. Or the land mass, right, These are like icebergs and the land mass, amount of land that there is for high paying mid management jobs in SaaS is collapsing. Right. So yeah, I think that's my take. I mean sales probably won't go away, but SDRs, any entry level stuff, support processes, anyone who's writing documentation, all those jobs just poof.

Don Whalen - **26:55**

Are going to be different, right? I mean you're gonna have one person who can write a ton of this stuff and using AI and who knows what it's going to look like. I mean I just, I. I watch videos at night and read up on this stuff. It's crazy. I don't know how quick it's going to happen, but I mean a lot of companies are already starting to do stuff with it, especially the tech companies, right? Was that what's his. Dorsey's company locks? I know Oracle just laid a bunch of people off. I don't know if it's all because of AI with Oracle, but you know. Yeah, that's what it seems, right?

Eric Zelman - **27:26**

I mean Keane said this quote the other day, which I thought was a. You know, again. David, David, this is a great David quote that right now his perspective is that CFOs and COOs are saying to companies, you can spend as much money as you want on AI and it's going to come out of hr.

Don Whalen - **27:48**

Yeah. I mean, you look at it like you can spend a ton. I was talking to a buddy of mine, he works at Broadcom and he's in the hardware division and he's got hardware guys that he works with. They're like, we're not getting enough tokens. I need more. Everyone's, oh, yeah, you know what I mean? You would think that's just strictly software. But he's like, why does everyone need all these tokens? And he's like, because they're in the hardware group. But it. Everyone is trying it, seeing what they can do. That's what I do. Every night I try to go between seven and eight or eight and nine, take an hour, and I just do something. It doesn't matter. Like, I'm not. You have an actual project. I'm kind of like, all right, I need to create a presentation or I'm getting leads from.

Don Whalen - **28:27**

You know, I use the MCP for zoom info and I get leads based on this and this. And it's amazing what it can do. And I'm just don't feel like I'm anywhere near what you or Brian Bean's done a ton of stuff too, with AI. So I'm just using it as much as I can for as many different things as I can.

Eric Zelman - **28:45**

So, yeah, I mean, It's growing really fast. And I think that David's point is that to me, is that anything that I built here, he was very complimentary. But I should be very cautious of thinking that first off, right now, people don't want to invest because the vibe is if, you know, anything like this, someone could build themselves. I mean, I don't. You know, I'm not a domain expert in this, so I just five coded this. So there's that. And then the question really is, in going with a tool like this, is that okay, since people could build it themselves, is this better off? As. Are we coming to a point in the economy where people like Eric, my. You know, for myself.

Don Whalen - **29:31**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **29:32**

Have a portfolio of, say, three, four, five of these kinds of projects and that we do consultative work for people where we show things, like David was saying. I mean, and I haven't pursued this at all. And I'll. But he was like, you know, Brookdale has no one who, in David's mind, no one at Brookdale knows how to do this. And that If Brookdale knew that they could do this, that could be something really valuable for them. But they don't. That's like, you know, he could be right or wrong, but he thinks there are a lot of mid market companies that just don't get this.

Don Whalen - **30:05**

He's right. Because I mean if you look at it, the tech companies are probably going to lead it. Or some industries where they're very forward thinking, but obviously tech, they sit there and go, wait a second, we have people just creating reports in Revops and we had a dozen people, now we need three. Right. And it costs a fraction of the price. And the people, the three people who know AI and you know that they're going to be the ones who stay on and maybe they make more money, who knows? I mean, or everybody's salary goes down. I have no idea. I just keep sitting there going, this is like the Internet was years ago, but it's moving much faster than remember people like I made a website, it's like, okay. And then, you know, e commerce and all that.

Don Whalen - **30:48**

This is just moving so much faster. It's staggering.

Eric Zelman - **30:52**

I had an interview, I had an interview last week. This is the though and I owe you this book. I told you I'm gonna finish it, I'm gonna send it to you. This is the book I forgot to bring. I saw you last time. The, the private equity book.

Don Whalen - **31:03**

Yeah, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **31:04**

But so I had this, I was telling my son about this today because he just, I was telling him, I don't know why I was telling him, not to make him feel better about the world but you know, and he's interested in these things. So I was like, I had an interview with a company last week that or two, a week and a half ago that is an AI startup. There's about 40 people in the company and they do AI to reduce health care bottlenecks. And you know from your wife, right. How this story goes that basically hospitals like they, so they're, they were born out of this organization called Northwell Health. And Northwell is the largest employer in the state of New York. And Northwell is like a conglomerate of 30 hospitals.

Eric Zelman - **31:50**

And Northwell internally built an AI tool to help cut back on the paperwork because it eats up 25% of the hospital's budget per hospital. 20 To 25% is administrative overhead.

Don Whalen - **32:04**

Budget.

Eric Zelman - **32:05**

Yeah.

Don Whalen - **32:06**

Holy wow. I wouldn't want it to be that high, but you're right in healthcare and hipaa. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **32:11**

And so they're like, if we can build an AI system that can, you know, the example they gave me was we can make it so that a hospital can discharge someone in half the time that it was taken two years ago. And because, you know, we know where we can make their appointments, their prescriptions, their instructions of what they to do when they go home, and all this stuff. And on the one hand, the cynical part of me is like, oh, it's like a restaurant. You just want to turn tables faster. But, you know, I get the reality of trying. Of like, you know, trying to manage through all this.

Eric Zelman - **32:44**

But the nasty edge to all this story, which is the PE end, is that the reason that this product is going to market and the reason that Northwell made this product is that Northwell is basically funded by a company called Deerfield Capital, which is a PE firm which buys up hospitals and guts them. And so what they did is that they started writing their own AI software to try to boost their profits. Right? And now they're marketing this software to other hospitals and other organizations as a. As a tool. And, you know, it's like, on the one hand, I, as a. Just a person, I'm like, okay, well, you know, administrative overhead for paperwork, like that sounds like a perfect use for AI. So I don't feel bad about it. The other end of that, though, right, is this.

Eric Zelman - **33:36**

Is this thing of, like, the race to the bottom of how much you spend on healthcare and how that. That same motion of we're going to do administration. You know, Henry, my son, was like, it's like, dad, it's not like that money is going to come back and go into care, into nursing. It's going to go into profits, right?

Don Whalen - **33:55**

Oh, yeah.

Eric Zelman - **33:57**

So, you know, there's. I don't know where all this stuff goes, but there's definitely, you know, some negative aspects to where how some of these technologies will be applied and how it'll affect, I think, our lives in some good ways and some bad ways that I don't think we have any guardrails for.

Don Whalen - **34:17**

Yeah. I mean, I don't know what direction it's going to go, but I'm trying to surf a little bit on the wave here of all the AI stuff just because I don't want to behind, like, the you're doing. And what Bean's doing is ahead of what I'm doing. But like I said, I try to do a project every night. Yeah, whatever. I'm like, take this newsletter and make a website out of it, you know, I mean, I know it sounds crazy, but I just keep trying.

Eric Zelman - **34:43**

But you have a salary, so True, true, true.

Don Whalen - **34:46**

But I mean, and I guess I just sit there and go, I see the value and I can see how a lot of companies use it. The question is where does it all.

Eric Zelman - **34:55**

Go and how you know, what's going to say? Yeah, I think automating, I think if you can do a project where you automate content that you're doing at Big Tin can, if you can find a practical reason to take anything in your sales pipeline and use AI to, you know, for modeling or figuring out just how to solve problems in your role, I think that's the most important thing, right? I think that, you know, like I, I think look at the reports, look at the data that you're getting or not getting, think about what are the things that I would, what are the questions that I just don't know the answers to that I wish I had answers to that are, you know, that you think about when you're like, what, you know, how will I make it through next quarter?

Eric Zelman - **35:45**

What is the unknown? And I think work those backwards. That I think is the driver because I think doing the newsletter stuff, it's nice and everything, but that stuff is going to just sort of wash away. And I think it's really like, I think you really have to look at it from like what's an actual problem that you need to solve. That's really the only way that these things become really useful and relative and relevant. Because otherwise it's like I did that, that cloud computing course through UT Austin. It was really interesting. But I'm going to forget all of it because I'm not using it in a day to day level because I don't need to. Because what I'm doing here has nothing to do with setting up servers and aws.

Eric Zelman - **36:26**

I mean I could do it that way, but that would just be a tremendous amount of work. And I'm like, I don't need it. I can just do it in Vercel. I can just tell Claude deploy in.

Don Whalen - **36:34**

Vercel and then, yeah, then it's done. I mean that's, which is amazing. So yeah, this is incredible, Eric. I swear this is a ton of work. But it looked, it's so cool. I'm just, I'm sitting there thinking like, yeah, you could be someone this companies could use this to say, oh, we have someone in this department over here who could fill this role. Almost like something.

Eric Zelman - **36:55**

Yeah.

Don Whalen - **36:55**

You know?

Eric Zelman - **36:56**

Yeah, yeah. Like, I think that one of the things that I Mean, there's so many possibilities. I mean, you know, it is that it's, you know, are we not like one of the things I asked the Goldman person, I asked her. I mean, it wasn't necessarily a problem that she had a lot of insight into, she said, with senior executives, because I think by the time that she, they got to the groups that she was working with directly, they're honestly making so much. And Goldman was so successful, why would they go anywhere? They probably didn't. But she said earlier, people early in their careers at Goldman would move around a lot more than people who had been partners for 15 or 20 years.

Eric Zelman - **37:32**

And, and that makes sense because, I mean, I think by the time you've been at Goldman for like 20 years as a partner, I mean, forget, like, just retire, you know, like a lot of money. You've made a lot of money. You don't need to be. You don't. You're just, you're working for fun. And at least in my mind. And so, but the early people, that's where those people would leave. And, and she was. And were talking about how this tool is a useful way of understanding those people's profiles and motivations and things like that so that you better insight into retention of employees, you know, so they don't leave the organization.

Don Whalen - **38:08**

No, And I, I mean, honestly, if I had two or three years of Goldman on my resume, I'd go somewhere else, too. If you can make more money and be like, wow, I got Goldman on my resume, I can write my own ticket. Anywhere you want to go, basically. I mean. Yeah, I've always thought they're the upper echelon of, you know.

Eric Zelman - **38:24**

Right.

Don Whalen - **38:24**

I don't know.

Eric Zelman - **38:25**

And they're probably a lot. You know, there's, there's. I mean, honestly, there are a lot of places where probably people make, you know, ridiculous sums of money and if that's what you want to do and I don't know that place, you know, but just saying, like, you're right, it has this. It, for the most part, as capitalism goes, it has one of the best reputations.

Don Whalen - **38:45**

It does. I mean, it's crazy. And it's been like that since I can remember.

Eric Zelman - **38:50**

Yeah. Yeah. So there it is, man. If you could, if you could do an hour with this in the next week,.

Don Whalen - **38:59**

Later this week, probably Thursday, maybe Friday, depending.

Eric Zelman - **39:02**

So that would be huge.

Don Whalen - **39:04**

It's unbelievable. I mean, it just, it's Cool. I. I don't know. That's a lot of work, but it really is. I hope this comes together. I know you're still looking for a job and all, but this could be a little side project that there's. There's definitely something here. There's definitely something there.

Eric Zelman - **39:21**

I hope so. I got the. I got the provisional patents of a year to work on to do that.

Don Whalen - **39:26**

That's good.

Eric Zelman - **39:27**

Do that. So that holds me off. Holds things off for a year. I filed an LLC the other day.

Don Whalen - **39:33**

Who did you use to file the llc? Did you just do it through this? The state?

Eric Zelman - **39:37**

Yeah, yeah, I just did. I just. Just. Rhode island has this, an online form. It took like, five minutes. He was used, Claude, to, you know, answer some questions about which boxes to check. Dumb stuff. So it's called Zelman Labs llc. And I did that so that I could get on so that later this week, once that clears, once the paperwork is done, and I can. I can then use that to apply through a government portal for. So I got my ein through that, and then. And then now I can apply for grants. I want to apply for an NSF grant.

Don Whalen - **40:13**

No kidding. Because when I did the. I created my wife's business for her medical spa. I used legal zoom again. This was five years ago, I think. And we created the LLC through that. Because then you have an agent here in New Hampshire. I tried looking at the New Hampshire website, and it. I was. I'm sure Rhode Island's website's way better than New Hampshire.

Eric Zelman - **40:33**

No, no. Rhode island is. Rhode Island's a freaking mess, man. Don't. Don't ever. I mean, that is an interesting race. I mean, like, I would imagine that in my. In my growing up in Boston mind, that Massachusetts probably has a lot more regulation than Rhode island or. Or New Hampshire for sure, but they probably also spend a lot more money on their internals than either state does. Because I feel like Rhode island is like the South Carolina of New England, not in terms of its politics, but in terms of infrastructure spending. Because it's just, I mean, you know, for good or for bad. I mean, like, yes, there's Newport and there's tourism, and there's some wealthy people here and there's a couple of universities. But the state, you know, like, it. It just doesn't have the cash that Massachusetts has by any stretch.

Don Whalen - **41:22**

No, neither does New Hampshire. I mean, New Hampshire's how many people in. I think we have 1.2 million up here in New Hampshire.

Eric Zelman - **41:29**

Islands a little less. It's like it's just like 1.1.

Don Whalen - **41:31**

Oh, is it? Okay, so similar populations. Obviously the land size is different, but I mean, I grew up in Connecticut. I don't even know how many people are in Connecticut, but.

Eric Zelman - **41:39**

Well, Connecticut's very well. And I don't even think sometimes about Connecticut as like New England, you know.

Don Whalen - **41:44**

I know it's. It is. It's almost like, oh, that's kind of part of New York north, sort of.

Eric Zelman - **41:49**

Yeah, it is true.

Don Whalen - **41:51**

A lot, A lot of my friends still work down in New York in the city. So.

Eric Zelman - **41:54**

Yeah, yeah. So I'm. Yeah.

Don Whalen - **41:59**

Well, shoot. So is. You send an invite, is that.

Eric Zelman - **42:02**

Yeah, yeah, I'll send. I'll send. It's. It's. This is an email with a link and a couple of. And a link to the. The form and the. Like a more recent version of a one pager you can read just in case you haven't heard enough about me going on about it.

Don Whalen - **42:19**

Listen, man, I'm. I think it's cool as. Because I. We work together for years that you're doing this and then I. Anything I can learn along the way, that's how I, I approach everything. I'm like, what can I learn? Like, if I learn one thing from us talking, but then I'll go through it. I'll just find like I'll just follow through the steps, through the whole thing.

Eric Zelman - **42:38**

Yeah. And like I said, if it, if it is just dragging you into the. Hey, Don, tell us about that time that you had, you know, 16 meetings and go into tremendous detail about all of them. And this will only take another six hours. Like just be like, no, no, let's go to the next one because like I said, I think after about really four or five minutes maybe. I'm not saying you should, but. And it might end on its own. Just Ravi's two hour experience concerns me. So I just want to make sure people don't fall into that boat. No, see where it takes you if it starts.

Don Whalen - **43:14**

I'll text you if I have any questions.

Eric Zelman - **43:16**

Yeah, cool.

Don Whalen - **43:17**

Well, listen, man, that's really cool, Eric. Thanks for running through it and I'll give it a shot later in the week if you just send the email over with the link in it.

Eric Zelman - **43:25**

I'll send it over right now, man. Thank you so much for your time.

Don Whalen - **43:27**

Talk to you soon, Eric. Take care.

Eric Zelman - **43:28**

Take.